THE RISE AND FALL OF BAGAN

The ascension of Arawrahtā marked the rise of Bagan as a regional power in Southeast Asia. Prior to the 11th century there were two rival centers of power in Burma, the Mon kingdom at Thaton and Bagan. Following the conquest of Thaton, Arawrahtā marched to Śrī Kşetra, expanding Bagan's influence and asserting hegemony over what is present-day Burma. He consolidated control by drawing neighboring city-states into a vassal status arrangement and creating the first centralized government in Burma. Between 1057 and 1059, Arawrahtā led an army to Nan-Chou in search of the Buddha's tooth relic. As he returned to Bagan the Shan kingdom of Mong Mao Long swore allegiance to Arawrahtā. Arawrahtā's successors Kyanzittha (r. ca. 1084–1112) and Alaugsithu (r. ca. 1112–1167) consolidated control over Burma.

Arawrahtā transformed Bagan into the religious and cultural center of Southeast Asia. He made Therāvāda Buddhism the state religion and received the complete Tripitaka, the earliest collection of Buddhist writings, from Ceylon. As a consequence of the religious scholarship, Buddhist monks and students from Yunnan, Laos, Thailand, and India came to study at Bagan. By the early 12th century Bagan had become a cosmopolitan center of Buddhist studies. It was during this period that many of the temples, pagodas, and stupas were built. Kyanzittha and his successors built more than 2,000 pagodas as well as thousands of lesser shrines in the 25-mile radius around Bagan. He is known to have personally commissioned the famous Ananda pagoda in which there were over 500 images of the Buddha, as well as building a large number of temples and religious monuments. Many more large temples were built later during Alaugsithu's reign. Most notably, the Thatbyinnya temple, Shwegugyi temple (great golden cave), and Dhammayangyi temple were constructed.

Kyaswa's (r. ca. 1234–1250) ascension to the throne in 1234 marked the beginning of a period of decline of Bagan. His large-scale construction projects depleted the royal treasury. Weakened by the continued expansion of tax-free religious landholdings and estates, the authority of the state weakened. Buddhism began to undermine the legitimacy of the state as religious endowments increased, while tax revenues decreased. Unable to reform the monastic establishment Kyaswa chose to withdraw from public